



BONUS 3 OF 5 · PRESERVATION

Store *to Sell*

The practical science of advance production, freezing raw and baked dough, heat-sealed packaging with silica gel and the three-day timeline for a 100-unit order without losing your mind.

- Real shelf life for dough, icing and finished decorated cookies
- What can be pre-baked and frozen · what absolutely can't
- The heat-sealed cellophane + silica gel packaging system
- The exact 3-day timeline for a 100-unit order (with hour blocks)

Third bonus of the five

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This bonus is your production planning brain. If you don't master this, three orders in the same week will destroy you. Master it and you can handle six.

CHAPTER 1

Real shelf life of every stage

What actually lasts how long — not what the internet says, what the cookies tell you.

Every stage of a decorated cookie has a real shelf life and a marketing shelf life. Use the real numbers to plan production. Use the marketing numbers on your customer-facing "best by" labels.

STAGE	ROOM TEMP	FRIDGE	FREEZER	WHAT LIMITS IT
Raw dough (wrapped)	2 hours max	3-4 days	3 months	Butter goes rancid, salmonella risk in warm air
Cut & shaped dough (frozen on trays)	—	1 day	2 months	Freezer burn if not bagged properly
Baked undecorated cookies	7-10 days airtight	Not recommended (dries out)	3 months in ziplocks	Texture change (softening or staling)
Royal icing (unmixed powder)	Indefinite in original packet	—	—	Original expiry on the packet
Royal icing (mixed, coloured)	4 hours covered damp	2 weeks airtight	3 months	Air exposure crusts, moisture loss
Decorated cookie (unpackaged)	7-10 days	Never	Never	Humidity, oxidation, colour fade
Decorated cookie (heat-sealed + silica)	3-4 weeks best, 6 weeks max	Never	Never	Icing brown-spotting after 4 weeks

1.1 • The one number you should tell customers

Tell customers **"best within 2 weeks"**. This is the honest sweet spot — the icing is still crisp, the cookie still tastes fresh, the colours haven't shifted. The cookies technically remain safe and edible for weeks longer, but you never want a customer eating one at the point where the icing sharpness has softened.

THE ONE THING THAT NEVER GOES IN THE FRIDGE

Finished decorated cookies. Ever. Fridge condensation lands on the icing surface as microscopic water droplets, which dissolve the icing into a soft, blotchy layer within hours. Freezer is worse — freezer burn destroys the crisp edge that defines a professional cookie. Room temperature in an airtight container is the only correct answer.

What can be pre-made • what can't

The stages that break the "one order = one production week" myth. Advance production is what turns a hobby into a business.

The single biggest productivity unlock in a home baking business is understanding which components can live in the freezer or the pantry until you need them.

2.1 • Freeze-and-forget: the components that keep for months

RAW DOUGH DISCS (WRAPPED)

Wrap each recipe's dough tightly in cling film, then in a labelled freezer bag. Freeze up to 3 months. Thaw overnight in the fridge before rolling.

CUT & SHAPED DOUGH (PRE-CUT, FROZEN FLAT)

Cut shapes onto parchment-lined trays, freeze flat for 2 hours, then transfer to ziplock bags with parchment between layers. Bake direct from frozen — add 2 min to bake time.

BAKED UNDECORATED COOKIES

Cool completely, ziplock bag with parchment layers between, freeze up to 3 months. Thaw at room temp inside the bag for 30 min before decorating.

ROYAL ICING (UNCOLOURED BASE)

Store in airtight containers with plastic wrap pressed to the surface. Fridge 2 weeks, freezer 3 months. Re-whip 30 seconds before use.

2.2 • What you CAN'T pre-make

- **Decorated cookies further than 3 weeks ahead.** The icing brown-spots and colours fade.
- **Freshly coloured royal icing more than 3 days in advance.** Air incorporation causes bubble craters when you re-use it. Better to freeze the base and colour as you need it.
- **Custom monograms or personalisation.** Always the last step, always fresh.
- **Painted work.** Alcohol-based painting done more than 5 days in advance can fade slightly under normal room light.

THE TWO-WEEK PRODUCTION RHYTHM

Once you're taking 3+ orders a week, run this rhythm: **Week A** = mass-bake and freeze undecorated cookies for the whole week. **Week B** = decorate to order from the frozen stock. Your Saturday production time drops from 8 hours to 4 hours because you're only decorating, not baking.

Heat-sealed packaging + silica system

The two-part packaging system that keeps decorated cookies looking fresh for 2-3 weeks after production.

The difference between a homemade-looking cookie and a professional-looking one is 40% decorating skill and 60% packaging. The system below costs pennies per unit and dramatically extends shelf life.

3.1 • The individual heat-sealed cellophane bag

Every finished cookie goes into its own clear cellophane bag (roughly 4x6 inches / 10x15 cm for a standard cookie), and the top of the bag is heat-sealed with a small handheld impulse sealer (\$15-25 from Amazon or WCS).

Why this beats the alternatives:

- **Ribbon-tied cello:** looks nice but isn't airtight — humidity gets in within 48 hours.
- **Ziplock bags:** airtight but look like leftovers, not gifts.
- **No individual bag, just the box:** cookies chip against each other in transit.

3.2 • Food-safe silica gel

One food-safe silica gel packet per 6-8 sealed cookies inside the shipping / delivery box. Silica absorbs residual humidity and keeps the icing surface crisp. Buy the food-grade version (labelled "FOOD SAFE" or "DO NOT EAT — SUITABLE FOR FOOD PACKAGING"). Never use the packets that come in your Amazon shipments — those are industrial-grade, not food-certified.

Source: Amazon "food-safe silica gel packets," roughly \$12 for 50 packets in the US. Squires Kitchen and WCS carry the equivalent in the UK/AU.

3.3 • Primary vs. secondary packaging

- **Primary packaging** is what's in direct contact with the cookie — the heat-sealed cellophane bag.
- **Secondary packaging** is the gift or shipping container — the kraft box with window, tissue paper base, silica packet inside, ribbon or sticker seal outside.

Both matter. Get the primary right and your product lasts; get the secondary right and it sells.

3.4 • Shipping-specific additions

If you ship cookies rather than deliver locally, add:

- Bubble wrap or crinkle-cut paper between the box and the outer shipping mailer.
- "FRAGILE" label on all four sides.
- Two ice packs in warm months (over 25 °C / 77 °F ambient) — not to freeze but to keep butter-heavy cookies from sweating in transit.
- Shipping speed: never economy in warm months. Priority / two-day only.

TOTAL ADDED COST PER COOKIE FOR PROFESSIONAL PACKAGING

Cellophane bag (\$0.05) + heat seal (equipment amortised, effectively free) + silica packet share (\$0.03) + kraft box share (\$0.30) + ribbon/sticker (\$0.05) = roughly \$0.43 per cookie. In a 12-cookie order this is \$5.16 of packaging cost, which the customer expects and pays for happily as part of the \$60-100 order price.

The five fatal preservation mistakes

Every one of these will destroy an entire batch. Every one of them is avoidable.

Mistake 1 • Packaging warm cookies

Cookie must be fully at room temperature and icing fully dry (24 hours) before sealing. Sealing warm traps steam inside the bag, which produces moisture spots on the icing within 6 hours. Symptom: little cloudy patches that appear on your finished cookies overnight for no apparent reason. Fix: wait the full 24 hours.

Mistake 2 • Storing in humid conditions

A cardboard box on a kitchen counter next to a running dishwasher, in a bathroom, or in a garage in a humid climate — all bad. Store in a dry, cool spot (bedroom shelf, dedicated pantry cupboard). Ambient humidity below 55% is the target. A \$20 hygrometer tells you where you are.

Mistake 3 • Freezing decorated cookies

Never. The icing crystallises, cracks and separates from the cookie surface. Freeze the components (dough, undecorated cookies) — decorate to order and hand off within 2 weeks.

Mistake 4 • Stacking without protection

Two decorated cookies stacked directly on each other chip and scratch each other's icing surface within minutes of movement. Every cookie in its own sealed bag, and inside the box every cookie sits flat with a tissue-paper or foam divider between layers.

Mistake 5 • Ignoring the "delivery day - 2" rule

Decorated cookies should be fully packaged and set aside at least 2 days before delivery. Rushing the packaging on delivery day means one of them will be smudged, one bag will be poorly sealed, and one silica pack will be missed. Slow down. Package day is a separate day.

THE SINGLE MOST EXPENSIVE MISTAKE

Combining Mistakes 1 and 4 — packaging warm and stacking. This ruins the entire order overnight. Every experienced baker has done this exactly once. Do not learn it the hard way.

CHAPTER 5

The 3-day timeline for a 100-unit order

The hour-by-hour plan for producing a hundred decorated cookies without a commercial kitchen, a helper or a nervous breakdown.

A hundred cookies sounds intimidating. Broken into a 3-day plan it's completely manageable. Here's the block-by-block calendar.

Day 1 • Bake day (Friday, ~6 hours)

TIME	TASK
8:00-8:30	Pull two batches of pre-made frozen dough from freezer. Weigh out ingredients for two more fresh batches.
8:30-9:30	Mix Batches 3 and 4 (fresh dough). Wrap and fridge.
9:30-10:30	Roll and cut Batches 1 and 2 (thawed). Freezer 20 min. Bake sequentially at 170 °C.
10:30-12:00	Continue baking. First trays cool on racks.
12:00-13:00	Lunch break. Batches 3 and 4 continue chilling in fridge.
13:00-15:00	Roll, cut and bake Batches 3 and 4.
15:00-15:30	Final cool. 100 undecorated cookies now waiting.

Day 2 • Decorating day (Saturday, ~8 hours)

TIME	TASK
8:00-9:00	Mix royal icing base (1.5x batch). Divide into consistencies. Colour into working bags.
9:00-11:00	Outline all 100 cookies. This is the fastest way — one technique, one bag, one motion.
11:00-13:00	Flood all 100 cookies (base colour). Every 5 cookies, tap tray on counter and toothpick bubbles.
13:00-13:30	Lunch. Cookies begin drying on trays.
13:30-15:30	Wet-on-wet accents on any that need it. Sprinkles onto wet flood while still wet.
15:30-17:00	Layered flood on cookies that need dimensional elements. First layers now drying, more accent layers as ready.
17:00-onwards	Leave to dry overnight. All 100 cookies drying on lined trays in dry cool room.

Day 3 • Detail + package day (Sunday, ~5 hours)

TIME	TASK
9:00-11:30	Piped detail on all 100 (text, monograms, borders). Any personalised elements done now.
11:30-12:30	Lunch. Detail work drying.
12:30-14:00	Individual cellophane bags. Heat seal each cookie.
14:00-15:00	Load into boxes. Silica packets per box. Tissue paper. Seal.
15:00-15:30	Label boxes. Photo for customer. Ready for handoff.

TOTAL TIME FOR A 100-COOKIE ORDER

Approximately 19 hours across 3 days. At a typical retail of \$6.50 per decorated cookie, that's \$650 revenue against roughly \$180 in direct costs. Net contribution: ~\$470 for 19 hours = \$24.70/hour before profit margin. This is why Bonus 5 (pricing) matters so much — if you underpriced this order to \$5/cookie you'd be at \$17/hour, which is not a business.

CLOSING

Your production calendar

The weekly template that keeps you sane at 3-5 orders/week.

DAY	FOCUS
Monday	Reply to inquiries. Send quotes. Confirm this week's production list.
Tuesday	Mass bake and freeze — undecorated cookies for the week's orders.
Wednesday	Rest day / office day (respond to inquiries, plan colours, order supplies).
Thursday	Decorate + flood the week's orders. Outline and base colour.
Friday	Detail work + packaging. All week's orders ready to hand off.
Saturday	Delivery / pickup day. High-margin day.
Sunday	Off, or reply to weekend inquiries and photograph portfolio.

This template scales. At 5-8 orders/week nothing changes except the size of the Tuesday bake. At 10+ orders/week you'll add a Wednesday second bake or hire a helper.

Production is a rhythm

Once you know what freezes and what doesn't, the panic goes away and the routine takes over. This calendar is yours forever.

Next bonus to open

Now that production is under control, open **Bonus 4 · Packaging That Sells** and learn how to charge 30-40% more for the same cookie with better presentation.